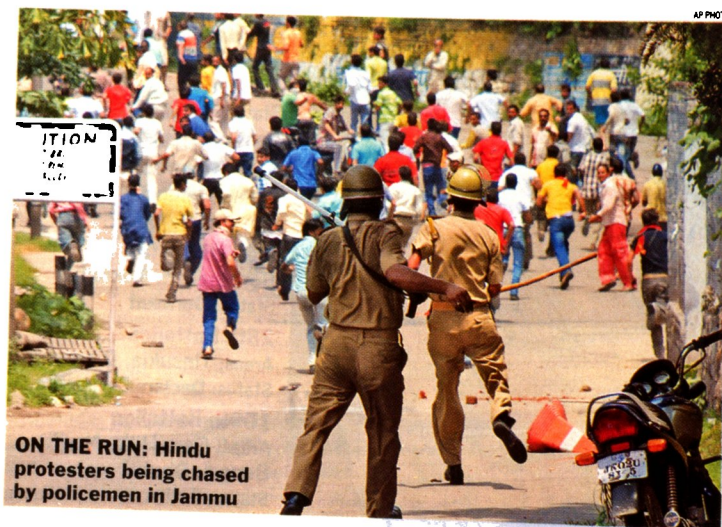


AN UNHOLY ORDER

The Government's flip-flop over land allotment to the ASB has exacerbated tensions in the state and gives BJP one more chance to whip the Congress



ON THE RUN: Hindu protesters being chased by policemen in Jammu



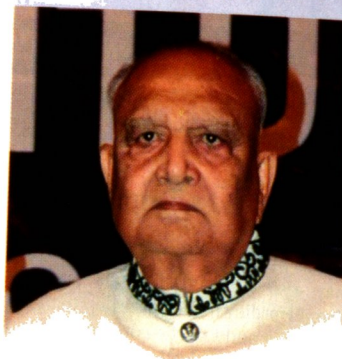
AP PHOTO

■ By Aljaz Hussain in Srinagar

It is never hard for politicians to indulge in flip-flops and some situations demand a lot of it. The controversy over transfer of land to Amarnath Shrine Board (ASB) and its subsequent revocation by the Jammu and Kashmir Government is one such. It would never have inflamed passions, had the Government made it clear that the land was being transferred to build temporary transit structures, and not permanent structures, for pilgrims. But, it has finally led to emotional outbursts across the country and polarised national politics, forcing the state Government to rescind its own order issued just a month ago.

The nine-day-long protests across Kashmir, biggest since early 1990s when anti-India insurgency began in Jammu and Kashmir, brought the state Government down to its knees. The revocation order stoked fire in Jammu and the polarisation between Kashmir

It was Sinha's persistence that led to land being allotted



S.K. SINHA

YASIN DAR

and Jammu reached its peak with right-wing political groups, including BJP, protesting against the order. The initial allotment of land changed the face of mainstream politics in the state. Sensing the popular mood across Kashmir, People's Democratic Party (PDP) withdrew its support to Chief

Minister Ghulam Nabi Azad's government a day before its ultimatum ended. "Agitation against the land deal was threatening to neutralise all investments made in peace and stability over the last several years," said Mehbooba Mufti, PDP president. "Azad's reluctance to rescind the land deal forced us to dissociate from his government." The move has killed all chances of a pre-poll alliance between the coalition partners.

Azad will have to prove his majority in the House on July 7 when Governor N.N. Vohra has summoned the legislative assembly for a special one-day session. The opposition National Conference (NC), as the single largest party in the House with 24 members, has already decided not to save the government. But, the fate of the government is not worrying the mainstream political players as the as-